

[IV. DEVELOPMENTS FROM JULY 1658 TO JULY 1662]

[45] Discourse on the Machine

Infinity, nothingness.

S680/L418

Our soul is cast into the body, where it finds number, time, dimensions; it reasons about these things and calls them nature, necessity, and can believe nothing else.

Unity added to infinity does not increase infinity at all, any more than a foot added to an infinite length. The finite is annihilated in the presence of the infinite and becomes pure nothingness. So it is with our mind before God, with our justice before divine justice. Yet the disproportion between our justice and God's justice is not as great as that between unity and infinity.

God's justice must be as vast as his mercy. Now, his justice toward the damned is less vast and should be less shocking to us than his mercy toward the chosen.

We know that there is an infinite, but do not know its nature, just as we know it to be false that numbers are finite. It is therefore true that there is an infinite in number, but we do not know what it is. It is false that it is even, false that it is odd, for the addition of a unit does not change its nature. Yet it is a number, and every number is odd or even. (It is true that this is understood of every finite number.)

So, we may well know that there is a God without knowing what he is.

Is there no substantial truth, seeing that there are so many true things that are not truth itself?

We know then the existence and nature of the finite, because we also are finite and have extension.

We know the existence of the infinite and do not know its nature, because it has extension like us, but not limits like us.

But we do not know either the existence or the nature of God, because he has neither extension nor limits.

But by faith we know his existence. In glory we shall know his nature.

Now, I have already shown that we can know the existence of a thing without knowing its nature.

Let us now speak according to our natural lights.

If there is a God, he is infinitely incomprehensible, since, having neither parts nor limits, he bears no relation to us. We are therefore incapable of knowing either what he is or whether he is. This being so, who will dare undertake to resolve the question? Not we, who bear no relation to him.

Who then will blame Christians for not being able to give rational grounds for their belief, they who profess a religion for which they cannot give rational grounds?

They declare, in proclaiming it to the world, that it is a folly—*stultitiam*¹—and then you complain that they do not prove it! If they proved it, they would not be keeping their word. It is by lacking proofs that they are not lacking sense. “Yes, but although this excuses those who offer their religion in this way and removes the blame of putting it forward without rational grounds, it does not excuse those who accept it.”

Let us then examine this point and say: either God is or he is not. But to which side shall we incline? Reason can determine nothing here. There is an infinite chaos that separates us. At the extremity of this infinite distance, a game is being played in which heads or tails will turn up. How will you wager? You have no rational grounds for choosing either way or for rejecting either alternative.

Do not, then, blame as wrong those who have made a choice, for you know nothing of the matter! “No, but I will blame them for having made, not this choice, but a choice. For although the player who chooses heads is no more at fault than the other one, they are both in the wrong. The right thing is not to wager at all.”

Yes; but you must wager. It is not optional. You are committed. Which will you choose, then? Let us see. Since you must choose, let us see what is the less profitable option. You have two things to lose, the true and the good; and two things to stake, your reason and your will, your knowledge and your beatitude; and your nature has two things to avoid, error and wretchedness. Since you must necessarily choose, your reason is no more offended by choosing one rather than the other. This settles one point. But your beatitude? Let us weigh the gain and the loss in calling heads that God exists. Let us assess the two cases. If you win,

¹ Paul, I Corinthians 1:18.

you win everything; if you lose, you lose nothing. Wager, then, without hesitation that he exists! "This is wonderful. Yes, I must wager. But perhaps I am wagering too much." Let us see: since there is an equal chance of winning and losing, if there were two lives to win for one, you could still wager. But if there were three lives to win, you would have to play (since you must necessarily play), and it would be foolish, when you are forced to play, not to risk your life to win three at a game in which there is an equal chance of losing and winning. But there is an eternity of life and happiness. This being so, if there were an infinity of chances, and only one in your favor, it would still be right to wager one life in order to win two; and, being obliged to play, you would be making the wrong choice if you refused to stake one life against three in a game in which, out of an infinity of chances, there is only one in your favor, if there were an infinite life of infinite happiness to be won. But here there is an infinite life of infinite happiness to be won, there is one chance of winning against a finite number of chances of losing, and what you are staking is finite. All bets are off wherever there is an infinity and wherever there is not an infinite number of chances of losing against the chance of winning. There is no time to hesitate; you must give everything. And thus, when you are forced to play, you must be renouncing reason to preserve life, instead of risking it for an infinite gain, which is as likely to happen as is a loss amounting to nothing.

It is no use saying that it is uncertain whether you will win, that it is certain you are taking a risk, and that the infinite distance between the **certainty** of what you are risking and the **uncertainty** of what you stand to gain makes the finite good you are certainly staking equal to the infinite good that is uncertain. It is not so. All players take a certain risk for an uncertain gain; and yet they take a certain finite risk for an uncertain finite gain without sinning against reason. It is not true that there is an infinite distance between the certain risk and the uncertain gain. Indeed, there is an infinity between the certainty of winning and the certainty of losing. But the uncertainty of winning is proportional to the certainty of the risk, in proportion to the chances of winning and losing. Hence, if there are as many chances on one side as on the other, you are playing for even odds, and then the certainty of what you are risking is equal to the uncertainty of what you may win — so far is it from being infinitely distant. Thus our proposition is infinitely powerful, when the stakes are finite in a game where the chances of winning and losing are even, and the infinite is to be won.

This is conclusive and if people are capable of any truth, this is it.

"I confess it, I admit it. But, still . . . Is there no means of seeing what is in the cards?" Yes, Scripture and the rest, etc. "Yes, but my hands are

tied and my mouth is shut; I am forced to wager, and am not free. I have not been released and I am made in such a way that I cannot believe. What, then, would you have me do?" That is true. But at least realize that your inability to believe comes from your passions, since reason brings you to this and yet you cannot believe. Work, then, on convincing yourself, not by adding more proofs of God's existence, but by diminishing your passions. You would like to find faith and do not know the way? You would like to be cured of unbelief and ask for the remedies? Learn from those who were bound like you, and who now wager all they have. These are people who know the way you wish to follow, and who are cured of the illness of which you wish to be cured. Follow the way by which they began: they acted as if they believed, took holy water, had masses said, etc. This will make you believe naturally and mechanically.² "But this is what I am afraid of." And why? What do you have to lose? But to show you that this is the way, this diminishes the passions, which are your great obstacles, etc.

"Oh! This discourse moves me, charms me, etc." If this discourse pleases you and seems cogent, know that it is made by a man who has knelt, both before and after it, in prayer to that being, infinite and without parts, before whom he submits all he has, so that he might bring your being to submit all you have for your own good and for his glory, and that thus strength may be reconciled with this lowliness.

End of This Discourse

Now, what harm will come to you by taking this side? You will be faithful, honest, humble, grateful, generous, a sincere, true friend. Certainly you will not be taken by unhealthy pleasures, by glory and by luxury, but will you not have others?

I tell you that as a result you will gain in this life, and that, at each step you take on this road, you will see such a great certainty of gain and so much nothingness in what you risk, that you will at last recognize that you have wagered for something certain and infinite, for which you have given nothing.

We owe a great debt to those who point out faults. For they mortify us. They teach us that we have been despised. They do not prevent our being so in the future, for we have many other

² Pascal's word is *abêtira*—literally, will make you more like the beasts. Man is in part a beast or machine, and one needs to allow that part its proper function: that is, one needs to act dispassionately or mechanically.